in which it was fought, lasted only a month less. Since the advances achieved in many weeks of costly fighting were a few kilometres at best, the war's reputation for futility is understandable.

EXPERIENCE OF WAR

Morale was often low in the later stages of the war. The idealism and patriotism so plentiful in the early days came to be in short supply. Soldiers cursed staff officers for their blunders and were horrified by the losses suffered. The experience of sitting passively under prolonged artillery bombardment shook men to the core. Gas attack was also traumatic, often more psychologically disturbing than militarily effective. Some men were reduced to a catatonic or incoherent state and identified as victims of "shell shock". They were few compared with the victims of terrible physical injuries. In the absence of antibiotics, yet to be invented, amputation was often the response to a wounded limb. But even a serious injury was sometimes welcome, for a "Blighty" wound would get you home and might save your life.

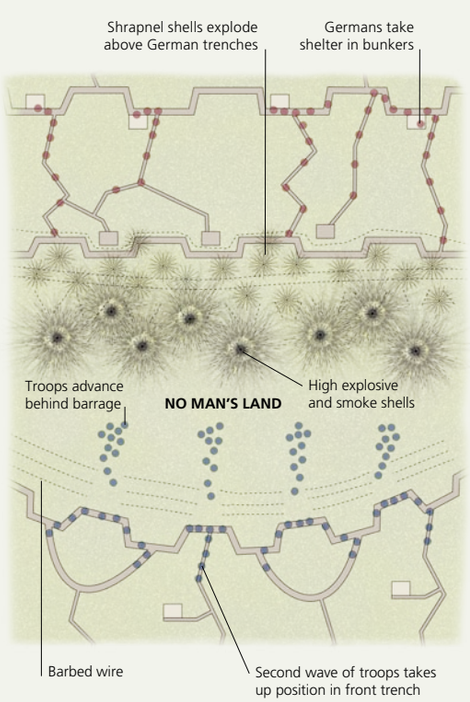
Yet despite all this, Britain's citizen-soldiers, mostly young conscripts by 1918, stuck to the fight and rarely wavered. Most took pride in the military skills they gradually learned and believed the war had to be won. They developed a feeling of comradeship with their fellows that many looked back on as the closest bonding in their lives. The courage and endurance of men taken out of civilian life and thrown into the most destructive battles the world had ever seen ultimately brought victory in November 1918. Many soldiers, disillusioned with the peace that followed, were later to look back on the war as a waste of young men's lives. But at the time most were quietly proud of their performance, regarding it as a hard job well done.

BREAKTHROUGH TACTICS

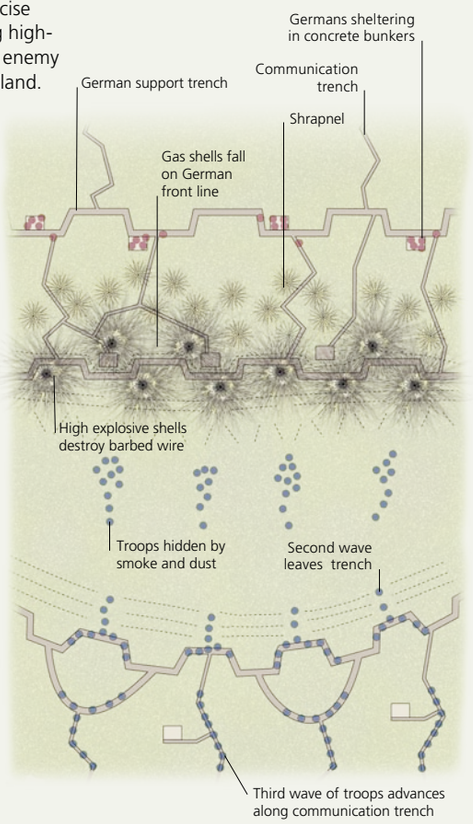
Frustrated by static trench warfare, the British army repeatedly sought a decisive breakthrough, to be achieved by punching a hole in the German line and pouring troops through it. By 1917 breakthrough tactics were well thought-out. A brief but ferocious preparatory bombardment was followed by the advance of infantry behind a creeping barrage. This curtain of fire moved forward at a prearranged speed equal to the expected rate of progress of the troops. By "leaning on the barrage" – keeping at most 50m (55yd) behind it – infantry could often reach the German front trench, which would be lightly held. Penetrating further through the trench lines was much harder. Forward observers tried to keep artillery coordinated with the infantry, but communications usually broke down. Counter-barrage fire rarely succeeded in silencing the German guns, which shelled advancing troops. Even if a hole was eventually punched in the German defence-in-depth, exploiting an initial success proved impossible because movement was too slow.

Launching an attack

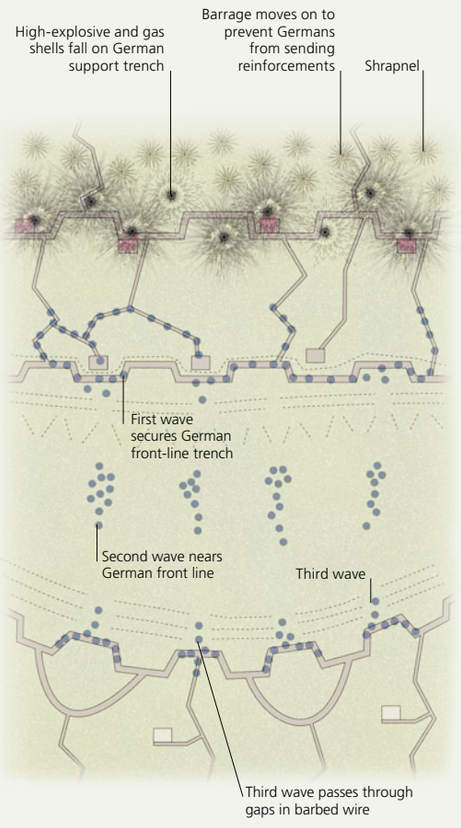
By 1917 a British attack on German trenches required precise cooperation between waves of infantry and artillery firing high-explosive, shrapnel, smoke, and gas shells. The guns kept enemy defences suppressed while the infantry crossed no man's land.



Dawn attack
The first wave of infantry climb out of their trenches under cover of darkness and lie on the ground ready to attack at dawn. At a prearranged time, the infantry begin to advance across no man's land, while the artillery lays down a creeping barrage ahead of them.



Creeping barrage
The barrage forces German troops to shelter in bunkers, allowing the British infantry to approach their trench largely unscathed. By the time the barrage passes on and the German defenders emerge to take up their positions, the first wave of British infantry is upon them.



Advancing in depth
After close-quarters combat the first wave secures the German front-line trench. The artillery now moves on to the second line of trenches, attempting to prepare the way for the second wave infantry, who will pass through the first wave and continue the advance.